

Pitchfork, for moving piles of hay, straw, and harvested cereal

Wheat

Oats

Rye

Barley

DAILY BREAD

Farmers grew various cereals, which were used to make bread. Expensive bread was made from wheat, while cheaper bread was made from barley and rye. If crops failed, people had to eat bread made from oats or even acorns.

Crook, to hold stalks together when harvesting with a sickle

Sickle, used to cut crops

HARVEST TIME

Simple tools, including crooks and sickles, were used to harvest crops. The harvested cereal was loaded onto a wagon with a pitchfork and taken away to be threshed, or beaten, to separate the edible grains from the chaff, or stalks.

Peasant's cart

Bristles cover the whole body

Pig

POSIES AND POISONS

Shakespeare used his knowledge of wildflowers when writing many of his plays. In *Hamlet*, the mad Ophelia makes "fantastic garlands" of "crow flowers, nettles, daisies, and long purples." The wicked queen in *Cymbeline* sends her ladies to gather violets, cowslips, and primroses, in order to make poison.

Primrose

Crops and flowers

Country life in Shakespeare's day was a never-ending cycle of plowing, sowing, and harvesting. The work was long and hard, and people's lives depended on the success of the crops. Nothing of what the countryside had to offer was wasted. Even wildflowers and plants were harvested for use in cooking, medicine, and the home. Shakespeare used images of crops, plants, and wildflowers to bring his writing to life.

Cowslip

Nettle

Sweet violet

Illustration of Ophelia from *Flowers in Shakespeare's Garden* by Walter Crane, 1906